ANNUAL REPORT 2023-2024

PROJECT: SWASTH JAL SHASHWAT VIKAS

Project funded by: Vaibhav Ashok Goyal charitable foundation

Location of the project: Tribal village of Vikramgad in Palghar

District of Maharashtra

Objective: Providing water for drinking purpose to marginalized community

VILLAGE PROFILE:

Distance from block place	No of families	Population	Cattle population
12 km	24	145	22

Vayam started working in Thakrepada three years back. The Gramsabha of the village is now well informed and understands how to take developmental decisions. The village had a grave problem of water scarcity. The borewell was the only source for drinking water. It got broken and stopped functioning two years back. The Gramsabha tried to fix it from Sarpanch. They got to know that he was of no use after few follow up meetings. Vayam witnessed their attempts and decided to help the Gramsabha by constructing a well.

Last year the work couldn't get completed because the site was wrong. This year we again searched for a new site and this new site has turned really well. The well has plenty of water even in the midsummer.

- All families contributed in form of labor worth Rs 7000/- to the Gramsabha.
- Villagers can have plenty of water to drink and to grow vegetables.

DPR PREPARATION

Vayam has been closely working with the communities to help them exercise their community rights on the forest. We have undertaken plantation activities in last two years. The activities were well intentioned but not organized. Vayam followed communities entirely from the site selection to plantations as we didn't have expertise and experience both. The idea had many limitations. Gramsabhas couldn't think about future. So, they couldn't see the problems.

Factors like the slope, water availability, soil pattern, existing farming practices etc were not considered while exercising the plantation activities. That affected the survival rate badly. We couldn't save 60% of the saplings from the last year plantation. That's why Vayam started working on plantation 24-25 from November 23.

The preparation activities are as follows:

- GPS maps of all plantation sites
- Family survey to understand livelihood options and income sources
- Geo tagging and the survey of all existing water resources
- Study of fodder and other NTFPs
- Monthly Gramsabha meetings
- Monthly trainings of Community Forest Rights management committees

- Correspondence with Forest department to make them understand the role of Gramsabha in the planning process

PHOTO GALLERY

PROJECT: SU-POSHAN

Nutrition at doorstep

Project area:

18 villages from Palghar and Nashik District

Objective:

Ensuring nutrition for marginalized Scheduled Tribes families

PREFACE

Annual report is an opportunity to rethink about the objectives and methods we have been employing. Team Vayam reached to every single family involved in this initiative to understand what they could make out of this endeavor.

Although we have been in constant touch with all the participant farmers, the conversations provided a different perspective. It was a joy of having fresh food available in the backyard. We were looking at numbers and the farmers were looking at the availability. They inspired us not to focus on the volume, but to look into the access to nutrition this project has enabled them to get.

Team Vayam feels pleasure and pride to share with you a year long journey towards Su-Poshan.

BACKGROUND

The project was designed around three main points. Things we think a farmer lacks and that results into unproductive human and natural resources.

- Availability of the material
- Training
- Monitoring and motivation
- Monitoring and motivation

We could provide essential material to the farmers to start with. Some of them added their finances in what we had given them to get more results.

Vegetables are prone to pests. In this region farmers do not cultivate hybrid vegetables species. So training for organic pesticide and fertilizer was necessary.

Lack of water makes it impossible to cultivate second crop. A few fortunate people who have irrigated land cultivate pulses and vegetables in Rabbi season. They invest money and labour, so it becomes a serious job.

In this initiative vegetables were supposed to be grown for domestic purposes. People here are not keen on having nutritional food. So, it would have been natural to give up taking efforts on supplementary food. That's why monitoring and motivation part was crucial.

ACTIVITIES

Documenting local seeds varieties	✓
exchange of seeds among participants	✓
collection of local varieties	✓
Geomembrane: Jalkund destribution	✓
Seed and saplings distribution	✓
Three monitoring visits for Jalkund	✓
monthly meetings with participants to discuss the problems and solutions	✓

Three monitoring visits in four months	✓
Training and demonstration of organic fertiliser and pesticide	✓
Prize distribution to one selected member from each village. A farmer who takes care of his/her vegetable garden and does extra efforts would be awarded.	✓

OUTPUT

Availability of the materials, training and monitoring are three required means we see as a output. Water, seed-saplings, pesticides and guidance are all we need to provide to a farmer for cultivation.

Availability of the material	Training	Monitoring and motivation
1.6m*6m geomembrane for storing water was provided to select farmers who weren't benefitted last year 2. Seeds and saplings 3. Herbal pesticide	1. Preparing the land 2. Making pesticide from the plants in proximity	1. Monthly visit 2. Monthly meeting of all participants at village 3. Sharing good stories of other participants 4. Displaying posters as a reminder

OUTPUT IN NUMBERS

	Villages	Participants	Participants who could retain the Wadi till Feb	Number of Jalkund distributed	Number of participants who used the facility	Participants who could continue using water from Jalkund till Feb
Objective	20	250	240	150	240	215
Outcome	23	240	149	151	215	148*

*17 sheets from the last year got torn.

*13 Participants used the sheet for other use

* 37 participants couldn't retain water in the ponds till Feb

OUTCOMES

Outcome can be seen through three dimensions.

1.Production of food comfortably more than existing needs

2.Participation of the participants should be taken as basic prerequisite. Vayam has been working with these villages since at least two years. Still, we measure our output on that criterion because communities we are dealing with are prone to any tiniest instability regarding weather, financial issue, social problems etc. So, we can't take their participation granted. We believe reaching out to every participant in every possible way is important.

3.Income generation from the surplus production

We can broadly say that first two indicators have been achieved successfully. The data supports the claim. However, income generation lagged behind due to inherent limitations in the design. We have discussed the issue at length in the end of the report.

1.PRODUCTION

1.1 JALKUND EFFECT

No of Jalkund	No of jalkund which are being used till the month of February	Total number of plants(mango, cashew, guava, jackfruit, Mogra etc) benefitted because of Jalkund	Orchard Farmers benefitted from the Jalkund
100(last year) +150 (this year)	148	5166	37%*

*38% of the remaining farmers do not have orchard.

1.2FOOD AVAILABILITY

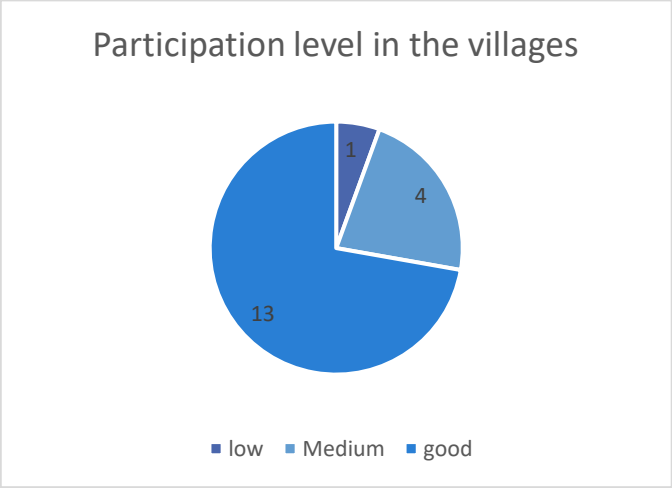
Consumption	**Surplus vegetables**
95% of the participants could enjoy vegetables in total 30 to 50 meals. That means they could save Rs. 2200 to 3500. The amount they could save is huge considering a family whose annual income is Rs 25000. In addition to that they wouldn't have spent that much money on vegetables which is least on their priority list.	47% of the participants could enjoy the joy of giving vegetables to guests and neighblour. For a farmer this is a thing of honor and pride to be a giver.

2.PARTICIPATION

Participation was measured in two categories.

A. Participants were required to complete the assigned work in time.

B. Participants were required to attend the trainings and all the meetings.



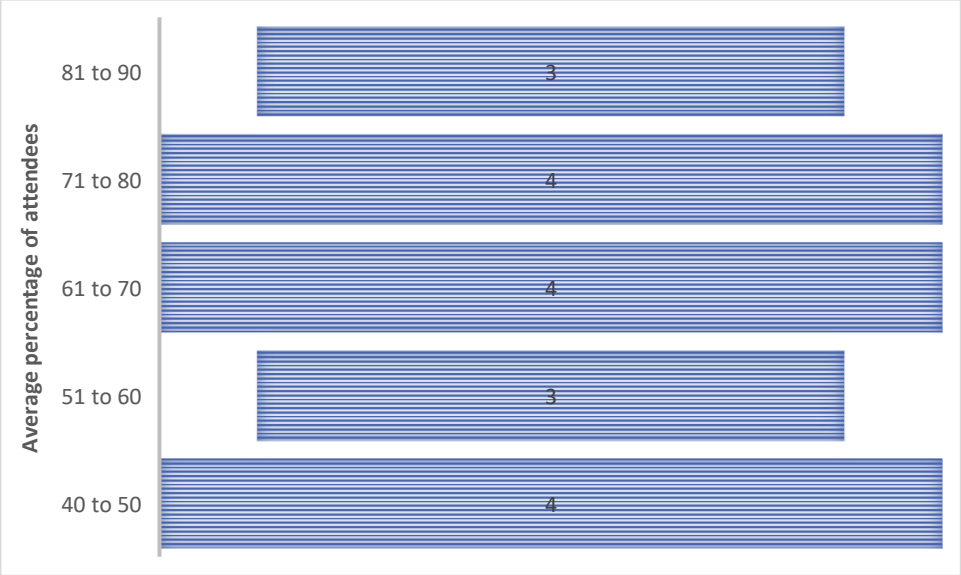
A. PARTICIPATION LEVEL ACCORDING TO BELOW GIVEN CRITERIA.

The pi chart shows how well participants responded. While rating the performance of the village we have considered response of 90% of the participants of that village.

The assigned work was included digging a pit, fencing the pond, preparing land, making pesticide and keeping records.

B.1. PARTICIPATION IN THE MONTHLY MEETINGS (NUMBER OF MEETINGS 4)

The average indicates the attence in the four meetings. We can see 7 villages below 60% attendence. The participants were not present in the village although the meeting schedule had been shared with them well in advance. Every village had one meeting with full attendence when we discussed the issue.



B.2 PARTICIPATION IN THE TRAINING

Training of making pesticide was conducted in the month of December. People who didn't participate in making the pesticide borrowed it from the other participants and used it. We discussed the behavior in the monthly meeting and strongly criticized it.

Participation in the trainings	**Training out put**
57% attended the training and made	**78%** participants used the pesticide

3. INCOME GENERATION

5% of the participants from four villages could sell the vegetables in nearby villages. The villages are Khairmal, Rautpada, Navapada and Sadadpana. We observed a pattern here:

1. Big size of the land invested in planting vegetables

2. Good source of water available near the farms

3. All participants who could sale the vegetables had surplus humun resource

ACKNOWLEDGING THE EFFORTS

Vayam acknowledged the efforts of few participants who put their hearts in their Wadi. They carefully nurtured the plants. Even put money to buy the seeds and saplings. Team Vayam identified 24 hard working participants from 18 villages and honored them in Gramsabha meeting/ participant's meeting.

It was a surprise for them. Everyone youngers or elders do like winning a prize. Other participants also acknowledged the efforts of their mates. They were given cooking utensils and tiffin box as a prize.

GROOMING AN ENTREPRENEUR

The project was needed around 13 thousand saplings of three vegetable species. Last year the saplings were purchased from an established Nashik based vegetable nursery. This year we thought of developing a nursery at our field office. The contract was given to our young village youth Ketan Baraf. He is resident of Khairmal and one of the participants.

He expressed interest and showed enthusiasm to learn the skill. Team Vayam helped him at every step from the scratch. He learnt communicating with material dealers, purchasing and growing seedings. Vayam also teamed him up with a veteran farmer. He guided him well at crucial stages.

Ketan couldn't provide the quantity as per the order we had placed. So, we had to buy the seedlings from the Nashik nursery. It did cost us around Rs 2500 extra. The cost was too little if compared to the skill Ketan could learn. Besides we could save on transportation cost.

It was a first of its kind of experience for Team Vayam. We too learnt a lot. Team discussed and documented what went wrong and why.

We are looking forward to repeat the attempt successfully next year.

OBSTACLES

In the last survey conducted in February participants registered following reasons for not being able to continue.

Reason	Pest attack	Destroyed by cattle	Lack of water	Migration	Reason not registered
No of participants	2.5%	8%	5%	11%	11%*

*Participants who neglected and didn't take care of the wadi.

LEARNINGS

1. In this region unattended grazing causes many problems after Diwali. Cattle do not spare any green patch in the vicinity. Bullocks are able to break literally any traditional fencing if they could see through it. So, participants were asked to take care about it. People confessed in the last meeting that they should have worked on building a strong fencing. Providing a sheet of shade-net to every participant may work well. That will add little cost but will ensure the longevity of more wadis.

2. We take assurance from the participants that at least one of the family members won't migrate during the wadi season. The data shows that in spite of the precaution 11% of the participants couldn't stay at home. Need to migrate can not be predicted. Some families do not migrate unless they face a strong need of more money than they could earn through the works under Employment Guarantee Act.

3. The Bhaji wadi initiative is small in scale. This is meant for domestic purpose. We want people should have access to nutrition. The scale has its own benefits and limitations. Large scale Bhaji wadi projects are taking roots in this region. That involves much more resources and monoculture. People care more when they grow for the outside market. We may think of scaling up in terms of the size of the Bhaji Wadi. Little more growing may add good number of vegetables in meals and on the other hand may help the family earn by selling surplus in nearby villages.

WHAT PEOPLE SAY…

People are happy to have home grown vegetables for considerable period of time. Here are some of the responses in their own words:

"I didn't buy anything except potatoes in last two months. It was incredible. I could save money and could eat chemical free vegetables at home." **Madhu Gund from Kashivali**

"I have been participating in this project from last three years. Now I feel no need to be dependent on someone to bring me vegetables from market place which is 12 kms away." **Shalu Pagi from Malkaripada**

"We could eat fresh vegetables because of the Wadi project. Otherwise we had to eat stale vegetables as we live far from the market. We don't afford going to the market everyday" **Ashwini Labad from Rautpada**

Bhajiwadi helped us saving the money. And in addition to that it inspired us to grow more vegetables. The experience has motivated me to scale up the wadi next year" **Shakuntala Baraf from Khairmal**

CHANGES IN THE DESIGN

Some of the data points have forced us to think about the design of the wadi we have been following from last three years. The initiative will primarily focus on nutrition support. Livelihood option is worth considering if incremental efforts can lead to meaningful results. We will check the capacity of the potential participants to invest more resources in this initiative. We may select resourceful farmers while considering weaker farmers for the existing model. So, that will be a combination of both types of farmers.

Team Vayam is thinking of having detailed baseline survey for good results. We implement this initiative in the villages where we are also engaged in other empowerment activities. That helps us understand the community needs and capacity better. We will keep it as it is with little addition of

detailed survey of the socioeconomic background as well as available water and land resources of the family.

PICTURE GALLERY

All the pictures of every participant at every phase have been uploaded on drive. Please visit the link.

1. Preparation

1. **maintenance**

3. Production

4.**Acknowledgement**